■ THE DAILY GOODS STORY SCOUT - Wednesday, August 26, 2026

TODAY'S RUNDOWN SLOTS

THE LIST (5 stories)

■■ *Ted Cruz basically just announced a 2028 grudge match with JD Vance*

The Angle: *A sitting senator openly admitting he wants the White House — and name-dropping the current VP as a potential rival — is exactly the kind of early 2028 shade that gets political junkies and casual viewers alike talking.*

- **Ted Cruz** said flatly, **"It's no secret that I want to be president"**
- The comment came on Texas Lt. Gov. **Dan Patrick's** podcast
- It sets up chatter about a possible **2028 collision course with JD Vance**

The Debate Starter

- Does Cruz actually have a shot against Vance in 2028, or is this just early primary noise?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 90/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 33 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/08/26/us-news/ted-cruz-teases-possible-2028-clash-with-jd-vance-i-want-to-be-president/

■■ *Dolly Parton's Got One Last Song Coming — From The Grave*

The Angle: *Dolly Parton has passed away, but she left the world one final gift: a secret song sealed away in a time capsule years ago, meant to surface only after she was gone. It's the kind of goodbye that turns grief into a genuine watercooler moment.*

- **Dolly Parton** has passed, but she's got posthumous projects still lined up
- Back in **2015**, Parton secretly recorded a song and sealed it in a time capsule
- The song's title: **"My Place In History"**

The Tribute Talk

- If you had to leave one song behind as your final word to the world, what would you pick?

variety.com (Tier 2) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/music/news/dolly-parton-song-buried-time-capsule-my-place-in-history-1236844669/

■ *Four chickens changed a family's whole future*

The Angle: *A grassroots farming program in Rwanda took families from struggling to feed their kids to actually building income - and the child stunting numbers back it up in a huge way.*

- One mother started with **just 4 chickens** given through a community farming programme to help feed her malnourished child
- Her flock grew to **7 chickens**, giving the family eggs to both eat and sell
- **2,700 households** across the district received chickens through the program
- Child stunting in the district dropped from **50.5% to 35.8%**

The Feel-Good Fact

- Four chickens turned into a food source, an income stream, and a measurable drop in child malnutrition for thousands of families - proof the smallest interventions can move the biggest numbers.

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL:
https://www.topafricanews.com/2026/08/26/ngororero-families-celebrate-saip-ii-gains-in-nutrition-food-security-and-improved-livelihoods/

■ *Rwanda park hasn't lost an elephant, lion, or rhino to poachers in over 10 years*

The Angle: *It's a genuine good-news underdog story — a park written off decades ago is now thriving, and the twist that actual former poachers are the ones protecting the animals now is the kind of redemption arc that makes for great radio.*

- **Akagera National Park** in **Rwanda** has gone more than **10 years** without a poached elephant, lion, or rhino
- Wildlife numbers jumped from **4,476** to **11,338** animals since **2010**
- The 'Big Five' — lion, leopard, rhino, elephant, buffalo — are all back in the park
- Nearly **60 former poachers** have switched sides and now work in conservation there

The Feel-Good Follow-Up

- Would you trust a former poacher more than anyone else to protect these animals — since nobody knows the tricks better than they do?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://allafrica.com/stories/202607030063.html

■ *Dolly Parton's Legacy: $9 Million to Neighbors, 200 Million Books to Kids*

The Angle: *Dolly Parton isn't just a country music icon — she's quietly one of the most generous philanthropists in the world, and this recap of her giving is going viral for how staggering the scale actually is.*

- Dolly reportedly gave **$9 million** directly to her neighbors in Tennessee.
- Her literacy program has now put **200 million free books** into kids' hands worldwide.
- The story's framed as a look back at her full philanthropic track record, not just one donation.

The Feel-Good Fact Drop

- Ask listeners: what's the most generous thing you've seen a celebrity actually do with their money?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.tvfandomlounge.com/philanthropic-legacy-of-dolly-parton-the-queen-of-country/

Backup options:

■ *Cops fake a speed camera, guy destroys it, gets three felonies*

The Angle: *A Florida police department set up a decoy Flock traffic camera as bait, a man took it out, and now he's facing three felony charges for falling for a trap that wasn't even real - the kind of 'you can't make this up' story that practically writes its own debate about entrapment.*

- Florida police allegedly used a **fake Flock camera** as part of a sting operation
- A man is now facing **three felony charges** connected to destroying the decoy device
- The story surfaced via **r/nottheonion**, flagged for its almost-too-absurd-to-be-real setup

The Debate Starter

- Is this smart policing or straight-up entrapment - would you side with the guy who took a swing at 'Big Brother,' fake or not?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.techspot.com/news/113616-man-charged-3-felonies-breaking-3d-printed-decoy.html

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■ *EPA may let data centers pollute without a public heads-up*

The Angle: *As AI-driven data centers get built out across the country, this taps into a real nerve: the fear that regulators are quietly stripping communities of the right to even know about — let alone fight — pollution permits in their own backyard.*

- The **EPA** is reportedly moving to drop the requirement for **public input** on pollution permits tied to data centers.

- The change would let **air pollution permits** get issued **without publicizing them** to nearby residents first.
- Critics are framing it as a direct move to **suppress pushback** against the data center boom.

The Debate Starter

- Should communities get a say before a data center's pollution permit is approved, or does the AI boom move too fast for that anymore?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/data-centers/u-s-govt-moves-to-suppress-pushback-on-data-centers-by-removing-requirements-for-public-input-on-pollution-epa-change-would-allow-air-pollution-permits-without-publicizing-them

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■ *China's hackers allegedly hit DOJ, NASA, the Fed, and the Senate*

The Angle: *This isn't some random data breach — we're talking about hackers allegedly getting into the Justice Department, NASA, the Federal Reserve, and the U.S. Senate. If true, that's a staggering breadth of access into the machinery of the federal government.*

- U.S. officials say **Chinese state-linked hackers** breached multiple federal institutions
- Agencies reportedly hit include the **Justice Department**, **NASA**, the **Federal Reserve**, and the **U.S. Senate**
- The scope suggests a coordinated espionage campaign rather than an isolated incident

The Debate Starter

- If hackers can get into the Senate and the Federal Reserve, is anything actually secure?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cnbc.com/2026/08/26/china-hacker-federal-reserve-doj-nasa.html

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CANADIAN NEWS (3 stories)

■ *Saskatchewan Slaps 50% Tax on American Booze*

The Angle: *Trade war fallout is hitting the liquor aisle — Saskatchewan is firing back at the U.S. with a price hike on American alcohol, and it's the kind of everyday-impact story that gets people talking at the bar.*

- **Scott Moe**, Saskatchewan's premier, just announced a **50% retaliatory tax** on American alcohol sold in the province.
- The tax is framed as a direct hit back in the ongoing **Canada-U.S. trade dispute**.
- U.S. booze brands on Saskatchewan shelves just got a lot pricier, overnight.

The Debate Starter

- Would you pay more to 'buy Canadian' at the liquor store, or just grab a different bottle?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://toronto.citynews.ca/2026/08/26/saskatchewans-moe-announces-50-retaliatory-tax-on-u-s-booze/

■■ *Try replacing Canadian aluminum? Industry says good luck*

The Angle: *Tariff talk keeps circling back to aluminum, and the industry's blunt message is that the U.S. simply can't swap out Canadian supply overnight — that's a real pocketbook story for anything made of metal, from beer cans to cars.*

- **Most U.S. aluminum** supply reportedly comes from **Canada**
- Industry voices are pushing back hard on the idea it can be easily replaced, essentially telling policymakers **'good luck'**
- Story ties into the ongoing **U.S.-Canada trade/tariff** tension

The Debate Starter

- If tariffs jack up the price of everything from soda cans to trucks, who do you blame — Ottawa or Washington?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.ctvnews.ca/business/article/most-us-aluminum-comes-from-canada-as-industry-says-good-luck-to-tariff-threats/

■ *Ex-MP busted with 445 guns and explosives in his house*

The Angle: *A former sitting Member of Parliament just got slapped with 26 new weapons charges after police found a small armory in his Manitoba home - the kind of story that makes you ask 'how does that even happen' before you get to the politics of it.*

- **Inky Mark**, a former Manitoba MP, faces **26 additional weapons-related charges**
- **RCMP** say they found **445 firearms** inside his home
- Police also seized **26.5 kilograms of explosives** from the property

The Debate Starter

- A former lawmaker with nearly 450 guns and 26 kilos of explosives under one roof - collector, prepper, or something police needed to stop?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/manitoba/inky-mark-weapons-charges-9.7321608?cmp=rss

Backup options:

■ *Hamilton-born Blues prospect hospitalized after freak training accident*

The Angle: *A 21-year-old Canadian NHL prospect is in hospital in Arizona after something went wrong during off-ice training — a scary reminder of how much risk athletes take on even away from game action, and Canadian hockey fans will want an update on one of their own.*

- **Matthew Mayich**, born in **Hamilton**, is hospitalized in **Arizona** after what the **OHL** called "an off-ice training incident."
- He's a **St. Louis Blues** prospect, drafted in **2023**.
- Mayich played minor hockey with the **Hamilton Huskies** and junior hockey with the **Ottawa 67's**.
- He's now **21 years old**.

The Get-Well Beat

- No word yet on what actually happened or how serious it is — worth flagging for listeners to watch for updates on a hometown kid's condition.

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/hamilton/matthew-mayich-hospitalized-9.7321818?cmp=rss

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■■ *PEI gets slammed with a possible tornado on camera*

The Angle: *A rare tornado sighting caught on video in Atlantic Canada during a wild storm day is exactly the kind of jaw-dropping weather clip that gets shared and talked about across the country.*

- Storm hit **eastern P.E.I.** on **Wednesday afternoon**
- Brought **high winds, hail, rain, thunder and lightning**
- Video captured what appears to be a **tornado** touching down
- Described as a **'wild day' of weather**

The Watercooler Clip

- Have you ever caught wild weather like this on your phone — play the clip and let listeners weigh in.

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/prince-edward-island/pei-storm-maritime-electric-environment-canada-9.7321519?cmp=rss

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■ *Canada's Biggest Icebreaker Heads Back to the North Pole*

The Angle: *It sounds like a science trip, but this is really about who owns a piece of the Arctic — Canada, Russia, and Denmark are all staking claims to the same seafloor, and this ship is Canada's way of backing up its case.*

- It's the **6th trip to the North Pole** for Canada's largest icebreaker.
- The mission is about nailing down Canada's claim to a slice of the **Arctic seafloor**.
- **Russia** and **Denmark** (through Greenland) are claiming the very same territory.

The Debate Starter

- Three countries are quietly racing to claim the North Pole floor — does that surprise you?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/north/canadas-largest-icebreaker-makes-6th-visit-to-the-north-pole-9.7321267?cmp=rss

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ENTERTAINMENT (4 stories)

■ *Dolly's saving one song for her 100th birthday*

The Angle: *Dolly Parton has reportedly locked away a final, unreleased song that won't see daylight until she turns 100 - a wild, only-Dolly move that gets people talking about legacy, mortality, and just how much we trust her to still be delivering surprises decades from now.*

- **Dolly Parton** has reportedly sealed away a final song not meant to be heard until her **100th birthday**
- Parton was born in **January 1946**, meaning fans could be waiting roughly **two more decades** to hear it
- It's the kind of legacy move that fits her brand - equal parts sentimental, savvy, and a little bit mischievous

The Debate Starter

- Would you rather get one perfect goodbye song decades from now, or have your favorite artist just drop everything they've got right now?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.telegraph.co.uk/us/news/2026/08/26/dolly-parton-final-song-theme-park/?WT.mc_id=tmgoff_reddit_parton-final-song-theme-park/&accesscontrol=facebookchannel_open

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■ *Garfield's New Movie Already a Mess Before It Even Drops*

The Angle: *A high-profile Andrew Garfield project is reportedly in turmoil over a Robin Hood storyline nobody signed off on - that kind of behind-the-scenes drama is exactly the Hollywood gossip that gets people clicking before the trailer even hits.*

- **Andrew Garfield** is attached to the upcoming film **'The Uprising'**
- The production is reportedly in **chaos** amid the fallout
- At the center of the mess: an **'unapproved' Robin Hood plot** that apparently wasn't cleared

The Debate Starter

- Would you rather a movie play it safe or risk a messy rewrite scandal like this one?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://metro.co.uk/2026/08/26/andrew-garfields-new-film-suddenly-chaos-unapproved-robin-hood-plot-29465527/

■■ *Dolly Parton Gets Name-Checked in Ruling That Kills Texas Drag Ban*

The Angle: *A federal judge just struck down Texas's drag performance law as unconstitutional - and reportedly leaned on Dolly Parton as an example of why the law was too broad, which is the kind of only-in-2026 legal-meets-pop-culture crossover that writes its own headline.*

- A federal judge ruled Texas's drag performance restriction law **unconstitutional**.
- The ruling specifically cited **Dolly Parton** in explaining why the law's language was overly broad.
- The law had aimed to restrict certain drag performances in the state.

The Debate Starter

- Would you have guessed Dolly Parton would end up as Exhibit A in a court ruling about drag laws?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.billboard.com/pro/dolly-parton-cited-by-judge-striking-down-texas-drag-law/?utm_source=reddit&utm_medium=social

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■■ *Rest in peace, Tim Curry — Rocky Horror's sweet transvestite, gone at 80*

The Angle: *Tim Curry's death hits a nerve because he's woven into generations of Halloween traditions and midnight-movie nostalgia — this is the kind of loss that gets listeners sharing their own Rocky Horror memories on air.*

- **Tim Curry** has died at age **80**.
- He was best known for his star turn in the cult classic **'The Rocky Horror Picture Show'** (1975).
- The film became a decades-long Halloween and midnight-screening tradition across North America, keeping Curry's performance iconic for generations of fans.

The Nostalgia Trigger

- Call in: what's your first Rocky Horror memory — the costume, the quote, or the midnight screening?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.reddit.com/gallery/1vz05zk

Backup options:

■ *Garbage Tells Ricky Schroder: Keep Your Dolly Tribute*

The Angle: *A random celebrity dust-up is blowing up on Reddit's gossip circuit — rock band Garbage publicly cursed out actor Ricky Schroder over his attempt to honor Dolly Parton, and the internet's picking sides.*

- **Garbage** — the band fronted by **Shirley Manson** — publicly clapped back at **Ricky Schroder**
- The flashpoint: Schroder posting what he called a "tribute" to **Dolly Parton**
- The band's response was blunt: told him to "f*** off"
- Story's ricocheting around **r/fauxmoi**, Reddit's go-to spot for celebrity gossip

The Petty Beef Alert

- Does Ricky Schroder even get to "tribute" Dolly Parton, or was Garbage right to torch it?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://i.redd.it/o2skslo13olh1.jpeg

■ *Ted Cruz accidentally boosts an account roasting his own anatomy*

The Angle: *A senator quote-tweeting (then deleting) a parody account literally named after his manhood is the kind of self-own the internet lives for - it's a quick, easy laugh that doesn't require any political deep-dive.*

- **Ted Cruz** quote-tweeted an account whose name mocks his anatomy
- The post was deleted shortly after, which of course made it spread even faster
- Classic case of a staffer (or the senator himself) not checking the handle before hitting share

The Screenshot Rule

- Deleting it never works - once it's screenshotted, it's forever, so was this a staffer's slip-up or Cruz just not reading the handle?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://i.redd.it/l89t0rk76slh1.jpeg

■ *Sparks star rips Enes Kanter in fiery trans rights rant*

The Angle: *A WNBA player going scorched-earth on a name-brand critic is exactly the kind of clash that lights up sports and culture-war Twitter at once - it's a soundbite made for radio.*

- **Cameron Brink**, LA Sparks forward, went off on trans issues in the league, calling it a **"non issue"**
- She accused critics of **"trying to just come for the trans community"** and said she won't stand for it
- She threw a direct jab at **Enes Kanter**, saying **"I don't even know what the fuck his name is... he's a stupid piece of shit"**

The Debate Starter

- Is Brink a teammate stepping up for her locker room, or did she cross a line going personal on a public figure?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://v.redd.it/sep6yh4ontlh1

■■■■■ *Rahul Kohli's t-shirt has fauxmoi buzzing*

The Angle: *A horror-movie favorite just used his platform to make a statement, and it's got the internet's biggest gossip forum talking — celebrity activism always splits a room, which makes for good radio.*

- **Rahul Kohli** — known for **Midnight Mass** and **The Haunting of Hill House** — posted a pic wearing a **"Protect The Dolls"** shirt.
- The slogan has become a recurring statement piece among celebrities, showing up on red carpets and social feeds as a nod to trans rights.
- The post is making the rounds on **r/fauxmoi**, Reddit's go-to spot for celebrity gossip.

The Take

- Does a celebrity wearing a message tee actually move the needle, or is it just a photo op?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://i.redd.it/duensz3dmqlh1.jpeg

TRENDING TODAY

■ *Dolly Parton's letter to Eminem has everyone in their feelings*

The Angle: *Two artists who couldn't be more different — country royalty and hip-hop's most controversial voice — showing mutual respect is exactly the kind of crossover moment that gets people talking, and it's blowing up online right now.*

The Feel-Good Files

- What's the most unexpected celebrity friendship or shoutout that's ever caught you off guard?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.indy100.com/celebrities/dolly-parton-death-eminem-tribute-letter

Backup options:

■■ *Surveillance Camera CEO Tells America to Just Deal With It*

The Angle: *Flock Safety's license-plate-reading cameras are already parked in thousands of towns nationwide, so when the company's own CEO tells the public to 'compromise' on privacy, that's not a local story - it's every driver in North America getting told Big Brother isn't going anywhere.*

- The company at the center: **Flock Safety**, the automated license-plate-camera network used by police departments across the country.
- The CEO reportedly used the word **'compromise'** when addressing privacy concerns - language critics are already calling tone-deaf.
- Backlash is reportedly **'major'** per the report, with the story blowing up on **r/technology**.

The Debate Starter

- Is 'compromise on privacy' ever a reasonable ask from a surveillance company, or is that just corporate-speak for 'get used to being watched'?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://deltiasgaming.com/flock-camera-ceo-asks-americans-to-compromise-on-privacy-amidst-major-backlash-report/

■■ *Meta's paying up to $18B over kids and social media*

The Angle: *This is a huge accountability moment for Big Tech — Meta agreeing to overhaul how it treats young users and pay out billions is the kind of story every parent listening has a stake in.*

- **Meta** has agreed to a settlement tied to social media harms affecting **children**
- The company could pay out as much as **$18 billion US**
- Meta has also committed to making operational **changes**, not just cutting a check

The Parent Trigger

- Would $18 billion actually change how your kid uses Instagram, or is that just the cost of doing business for Meta?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/business/meta-social-media-harms-settlement-9.7320919?cmp=rss

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LIFESTYLE CHAT

■ *Your Google Search Is Draining California's Water Supply*

The Angle: *A new study claims data centers now slurp up more water than entire California cities - a wake-up call for anyone who didn't realize every AI chat and Netflix stream has a hidden water bill attached.*

The Debate Starter

- Should tech giants have to publish exactly how much water your searches and streams are costing your town?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.bgov.com/environment-and-energy/data-centers-use-more-water-than-california-cities-study-says

Backup options:

■ *Study Says Women Fake Wanting It... 2.5 Times a Month*

The Angle: *New research puts a hard number on something couples rarely talk about out loud — how often partners have sex even when the desire just isn't there — and it's a guaranteed relationship-talk starter for any couple listening in the car.*

- Researchers studied women who report a **chronic lack of sexual desire** but still stay sexually active with partners.
- The behavior — sometimes called **"mercy sex"** — was clocked at roughly **two and a half times per month**.
- The study frames it as a quantified pattern, not a one-off — meaning it's routine for a lot of couples, not rare.

The Debate Starter

- Is doing it 'for your partner' when you're not in the mood generous, or is it setting up resentment down the line?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.psypost.org/clinical-trials-reveal-the-hidden-frequency-of-obligatory-sex-in-women-with-low/

■ *Could hormone therapy actually protect your brain?*

The Angle: *New research suggests women on hormone replacement therapy may have a lower risk of dementia - a hot-button topic given how many women hit menopause wondering if HRT is worth the risks, and this could flip the script on that conversation.*

The Debate Starter

- Ladies, would this kind of finding change your mind on hormone therapy - or are you still team "no thanks"?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.theguardian.com/society/2026/aug/26/women-hrt-lower-risk-dementia-study

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CLOSER: THE KICKER/GOODBYES

■ *The one thing Democrats and Republicans finally agree on? No AI data centers next door*

The Angle: *In a country that can't agree on anything, NIMBY concerns over massive AI data centers - the noise, the power bills, the water use - are apparently bipartisan. It's a rare unity story with a fun "wait, really?" hook for a kicker.*

The Unlikely Alliance

- What's the one issue you'd actually agree on with someone from the opposite side of the aisle?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://apnews.com/article/data-centers-bipartisan-opposition-trump-democrats-a419be82fb6b32a8fc048ac7ffbd1de3

Backup options:

■ *Ubisoft Ships a Game... Without the Game Part*

The Angle: *It's the kind of corporate fumble that writes itself — a classic strategy game re-release tanks on Steam because the actual game reportedly isn't in it, and gamers are roasting it in real time on Reddit.*

- **Heroes of Might and Magic III** just got hit with a **'Mostly Negative'** rating on Steam.
- The reported reason: **Ubisoft** apparently forgot to actually include the game in the release.
- The story's currently blowing up on **r/nottheonion** for being almost too absurd to be real.

The Corporate Facepalm

- What's the most broken, half-finished product you've ever paid full price for?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.xda-developers.com/heroes-of-might-and-magic-iii-hits-mostly-negative-steam-reviews-because-ubisoft-forgot-to-add-the-game/

FLEX (cap check: THE GREAT DEBATE 1/4 this month; TECH TALK 3/3 this month; Advice/Relationship Cluster 3/3 this month)

(no flex-slot candidates cleared the cap/score bar today)

BREAKOUT WATCH (below the show's usual engagement bar - included on editorial judgment, not metrics; producer's call)

■ *Panda Express bosses want to buy YOU a house*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Fast-food CEOs bankrolling home ownership is a surprising, feel-good corporate story with instant brand recognition that outlets love recirculating.
The Angle: *It's the kind of feel-good corporate story that stops people mid-scroll — a fast food chain's CEOs reportedly making employee homeownership a personal mission, which is exactly the warm, watercooler close this show loves to end on.*

- The story centers on **Panda Express's CEOs** and a stated **"mission"** to help their own workers become homeowners.
- Framed as a feel-good workplace benefit story, not a typical corporate press release.

The Feel-Good Finisher

- Would you switch jobs for a boss who helped you buy a house?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.nbcnews.com/business/ceo-interviews/panda-express-ceos-employee-home-ownership-rcna594191

■ *Zelenskyy just handed Elon Musk Ukraine's top honor*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Musk plus Zelenskyy plus a genuinely surprising reversal of years of public criticism is a built-in controversy magnet that both pro- and anti-Musk crowds will amplify.
The Angle: *This is the kind of head-scratcher that makes people do a double take — Musk has spent years publicly sparring with Zelenskyy over Starlink, funding, and the war itself, and now he's getting the country's highest award anyway.*

- **Volodymyr Zelenskyy** awarded **Elon Musk** one of **Ukraine's top honours**
- The award comes after **years of public friction** between the two, including Musk's past criticism of Zelenskyy and Ukraine's war strategy
- Story is making the rounds specifically because of how unexpected the pairing is

The Head-Scratcher

- Would you give your harshest critic a medal — or is this just smart diplomacy?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.euronews.com/my-europe/2026/08/26/zelenskyy-awards-elon-musk-ukraines-order-of-freedom-despite-years-of-criticism

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■■ *Alaska Senate Race: It's Dan Sullivan vs. Dan Sullivan*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A self-contained absurdist headline (a man beating his own namesake in a Senate primary) is exactly the kind of one-line joke that spreads on its own with zero context needed.
The Angle: *A U.S. Senate race where both major candidates share the exact same name is the kind of real-life absurdity that writes its own punchline - and it's a genuine ballot mix-up risk for actual voters.*

The Debate Starter

- How do you even attack your opponent in ads when you'd technically be saying your own name?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.notus.org/campaigns/dan-sullivan-advances-alaska-senate-race-name

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■ *Buckingham Palace guards just went full Dolly Parton*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Buckingham Palace guards playing a Dolly Parton hit is a proven viral format (stiff British ceremony meets pop culture) tied to one of the most universally beloved celebrities alive.
The Angle: *The King's Guard swapping their usual marching tunes for a Dolly Parton hit is exactly the kind of unexpected, shareable moment that blows up online - serious royal pageantry colliding with country pop.*

- **Buckingham Palace** guards performed **Dolly Parton's "9 to 5"** during their changing-of-the-guard routine
- The moment is being celebrated as a tribute to the country music icon

The Watercooler Moment

- What's the last song you'd ever expect to hear from the Queen's Guard - call in with your pick.

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/videos/cx2zyxdy9mjo

■ *Browns Fans Protest Watson by Trashing Jim Brown's Statue*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Fan backlash aimed at a Jim Brown statue over the Deshaun Watson QB decision lands right as NFL season kicks off, giving it built-in sports-controversy timing.
The Angle: *Deshaun Watson getting named the Browns' starter is reigniting a controversy that's dogged the team for years, and fans are so fed up they're using a franchise legend's own statue to make their point — that's the kind of visual that goes viral fast.*

- **Browns** fans placed protest signs directly on the **Jim Brown** statue outside the team's stadium
- The protest is a direct response to **Deshaun Watson** being named the team's starting quarterback

- **Jim Brown** is a Hall of Fame legend and one of the most revered figures in franchise history — using his statue as the protest site is the real sting here

The Debate Starter

- Is it fair for fans to drag a franchise legend's statue into a QB controversy, or is that exactly the kind of stunt that gets a team's attention?

X/Twitter @NYPost (Tier 1) | Score: 72/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 15 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/nypost/status/2092793136326103377

■ *Cops kill a college kid at the wrong front door?*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A wrong-house police killing of a college student pattern-matches prior stories that went national (echoes of Ralph Yarl), and that emotional/outrage hook travels fast once picked up.
The Angle: *A grieving father says police shot and killed his son, a college student, after officers went to the wrong address in Pennsylvania — the kind of story that instantly raises hard questions about police tactics and accountability that resonate everywhere, not just locally.*

- The victim's **father** says his son was a **college student**
- The shooting happened in **Pennsylvania**
- The family claims police were responding to the **wrong house**

The Debate Starter

- When a mistaken address turns fatal, who's actually accountable — the officers on scene, or the system that sent them there?

X/Twitter @CTVNews (Tier 1) | Score: 52/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 5 quality - 10 penalty (Depressing/negative tone)) -> STRONG

URL: https://x.com/CTVNews/status/2092719111147073778

FRANCHISE BANK

WHAT THE FRIDAY: 3 banked (+15 each when found)
- "NYC women's shelter brings cat fights, junkies and bizarre antics to neighborhood near playground https://t.co/khWuUTWRRt https://t.co/HwXL2" (X/Twitter @NYPost, banked 2026-08-13)
- "Hayden Panettiere was haunted by crippling back pain from bizarre on-set zebra accident" (nypost.com, banked 2026-08-19)
- "Abdul El-Sayed asks Fox News' Jesse Watters 'Are you circumcised?' in bizarre moment as he defends sex change surgery for minors https://t.c" (X/Twitter @NYPost, banked 2026-08-24)

THROWBACK THURSDAY: 14 banked (+15 each when found)
- "Jake T. Austin Says He Wasn't Invited to Partake in 'Wizards of Waverly Place' Revival: "Disappointed"" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-08-07)
- "Japan commemorates 81st anniversary of the atomic bombing of Nagasaki - ctvnews.ca" (CTV News (via Google News), banked 2026-08-09)
- "Where to Watch 'Real Housewives Ultimate Girls Trip: Roaring 20th' Anniversary Series Online" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-08-09)
- "Animal Justice holds one year anniversary rally at St. Joseph's Hospital" (CTV News (via Google News), banked 2026-08-10)
- ""Roseanne" Child Star Michael Fishman Slams Idea That the Show's Revival Was Unjustly Canceled: 'Words Have Consequences' - Yahoo" (PEOPLE (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-08-11)
- "Lee Daniels, Nadine Labaki, Marina Abramovic Win Liberatum Pioneer Awards (Exclusive)" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-08-12)
- "Chip Gaines Makes Rare Appearance with Wife Joanna on Magnolia Journal's Milestone 10th Anniversary Cover - People.com" (People (via Google News), banked 2026-08-14)
- "'Cause we (still) rock! The Jonas Brothers introduce a new generation in nostalgia-filled Camp Rock 3 (exclusive)" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-08-14)
- "Ugly inning, quiet bats doom Yankees in disappointing loss to Blue Jays" (nypost.com, banked 2026-08-14)

- "JENNIE hears the BLINKs, and now, she’s sharing regrets from her heart after fans expressed they were feeling let down by the lack of celebr" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-08-17)
- "Vin Diesel and Meadow Walker arrive to "The Fast and the Furious" 25th Anniversary Screening in LA https://t.co/zDNowKjfdg" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-08-17)
- "JENNIE Offers Heartfelt Apology After Fans Felt ‘Disappointed’ by BLACKPINK’s 10th Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-08-18)
- "Pokémon 30th Anniversary TCG Set Might Feature Rarest Mew Ever - Kotaku" (Kotaku (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-08-21)
- "Sonic the Hedgehog to Headline Fortnite’s ‘Override’ Season (Gaming News Roundup)" (variety.com, banked 2026-08-22)

SOURCES SKIPPED THIS RUN:

- @EdNewtonRex (fetch failed)
- @CBCNews (fetch failed)
- @Gizmodo (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- Morning Brew (OpenCLI browser-scrape returned nothing - check Chrome/bridge)

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